REPORT

OF THE

MINISTER FOR AGRICULTURE

ON THE

SEA AND INLAND FISHERIES

FOR THE YEAR

1944.

PART I.

SEA FISHERIES.

The year 1944 was a satisfactory one for our sea fishing industry. The comparative figures of quantity and value of landings (exclusive of shellfish) made in each of the past six years are as follows:—

Year	Cwt.	£
1944	306,869	513,063
1943	277,911	510,970
1942	252,703	433,650
1941	275,793	499,904
1940	224,755	267,482
1939	187,949	196,199

The total realised for shellfish was £112,683 (against £99,687 in 1943) bringing the value for all classes of sea-fish taken in 1944 to £625,746, an increase of approximately £15,000 on the previous year's figure of £610,657, which had been the highest reached in any of the preceding twenty-five years. The main centres of activity during 1944, placed in order of value of catches, were Dublin, Howth, Valentia Harbour, Dingle, Killybegs, Kinsale, Loughshinny, Baltimore, Galway, Clogher Head, Helvick, Schull and Arklow. The landings at Dublin were almost entirely from the small fleet of deep sea-trawlers based there.

During the year under review only one licence was issued under the provisions of the Fish (Regulation of Imports) (No. 2) Order, 1938. It covered a small quantity of whiting landed by three Northern Ireland vessels weatherbound at Clogher Head.

DEMERSAL FISHERY.—The quantity of demersal fish taken in 1944 was 139,771 cwt., an increase of almost 21% on the 1943 figure of 115,624 cwt.; and was the highest recorded for twenty-three years. The value for 1944 at £375,343 compared favourably with £341,184 for 1943, and was the highest for any year since 1922. Of the catch of demersal fish 18,170 cwt. came from

131 trips made by the three Dublin deep-sea trawlers; the figures for 1943 being 12,209 cwt. and 77 trips. The general increase for 1944 was, therefore, attributable in the main to the inshore boats with small trawls and long lines operating from points such as Howth, Dingle, Killybegs, Loughshinny, Baltimore, Clogher Head, Galway, and Schull. Particulars of the quantities according to varieties will be found in Appendix No. 1 (page 13).

PELAGIC FISHERY.—**Herrings.**—The following table shows the quantity and value of herrings landed in each of the past ten years and the average price per cwt. realised by the fishermen:—

Year	Cwt.	£	Average Value per cwt.
			s. d.
1944	77,538	81,982	21 2
1943	76,698	90,908	23 8
1942	38,992	41,110	21 1
1941	78,586	82,349	21 0
1940	71,081	56,154	15 10
1939	50,660	24,289	9 7
1938	56,829	19,288	6 9
1937	64,318	23,676	7 4
1936	62,273	23,895	7 8
1935	64,799	25,997	8 0

It will be noted that, although the value for 1944 was less than the figure for 1943, the quantity landed was somewhat greater and was only slightly below that for 1941, the highest for any year since 1929. The summer fishing was mainly associated with Howth and Kinsale, which between them accounted for more than half the catch. The winter fishing was more evenly spread around the coast and only at Bunbeg did the landings exceed 4,000 cwt.

Greater details of these summer and winter fishings will be found in Appendices Nos. 5 and 6.

Mackerel.—The quantity and value of mackerel landed in each of the past ten years were:—

Year	Cwt.	£	Average Value per cwt.
			s. d.
1944	88,294	55,270	12 6
1943	84,105	78,125	18 7
1942	76,618	59,418	15 6
1941	99,479	167,311	33 8
1940	60,820	30,086	9 11
1939	46,094	16,516	7 2
1938	35,639	12,844	7 2
1937	48,808	16,352	6 8
1936	44,179	13,674	6 2
1935	34,471	10,592	6 2

Here again the quantity landed in 1944 was higher than that for any of the preceding fifteen years with the exception of 1941. Over 51,000 cwt. was taken during the spring fishing and some 37,000 cwt. in the autumn. In each case the figures for Valentia Harbour greatly exceeded those of other places and represented almost one-half of the entire catch. The returns in more detailed form will be found in Appendices Nos. 7 and 8.

SHELLFISH.—Shellfish continued to provide a good proportion of the income of communities residing on the coast. The value of the various kinds taken in 1944 was £112,683, an increase of some 13% on the figure for 1943 which was in turn some 40% higher than that for 1942. The principal varieties in 1944, in order of value, were lobsters, escallops, periwinkles, oysters and mussels. Lobster fishing and periwinkle gathering are common to a great portion of our coastline; escallops are taken mainly in the Bantry Bay and Connemara areas; the principal oyster beds at present exploited are in the south east portion of Galway Bay; mussels for human consumption come almost entirely from Castlemaine Harbour, Co. Kerry and Omeath, Co. Louth, but considerable quantities of mussels, presumably for use as bait, were exported during 1944 and previous years from Dundalk Bay and the Boyne district. The improvement in lobster fishing, which was observed in 1943 continued during 1944, particularly off the Donegal coast. The Irish Sea Fisheries Association engaged at Galway in the experimental marketing of frozen escallops. The process consists of removing the escallops from their shells, freezing the edible portion, and then despatching to market the frozen product in water-proof cartons. This innovation evidently gave a fillip to the dredging of escallops in Connemara, where the quantity taken in 1944 was more than treble that for 1943, while the value to the dredgers increased substantially. Although the gathering of periwinkles and mussels proved to be not so remunerative in 1944 as in 1943, the quantity of oysters taken was approximately double that for 1943, the increase showing almost entirely within the Galway Bay area. Unfortunately, however, the high price obtainable resulted in a growing tendency to contravene the regulations designed for the conservation of natural stock and this may eventuate in irreparable damage to the oyster beds.

PERSONNEL AND VESSELS.—The increased interest in the sea fishing industry as a means of livelihood manifested in recent years continued during 1944 when the number of men engaged increased to 9,879 from 9,646 for 1943. Of these 1,925 were engaged whole-time and 7,954 found part-time employment in the business (the corresponding figures for 1943 were 1,977 and 7,669).

The number of vessels of all types engaged solely or partially at fishing increased to 3,439 in 1944 as against 3,387 in 1943. The number of steam trawlers remained constant at three; the numbers of motor and sail driven boats in commission each dropped by ten in 1944; while the number of fishing craft propelled by oars increased by 52 during the year.

The regional distribution and classification of fishing craft for 1944 is shown in Appendix No. 4.

CASUALTIES.—Three fatal accidents have to be recorded in respect of 1944. One occurred in July off Carrigan Head, Co. Donegal, when a member of a seiner's crew was lost overboard in a choppy sea. The other two fatalities occurred in October, the first at Cobh where the snapping of the helm of a fishing boat caused the steersman to topple overside; and the second off Dun Laoghaire when a fisherman struck by a boom was swept into the sea.

SCIENTIFIC AND TECHNICAL INVESTIGATIONS.—The routine biological examination of herring samples collected from various landing places was maintained during 1944. A paper on the herring fisheries for the period 1921 to 1941, the completion of which was mentioned in the 1943 Report, was duly published in the Department's Journal in 1944. An account by the Chief Inspector of Fisheries of the Irish names of fishes, giving the vernacular names used in parts of the Gaeltacht, which had involved much research work in its compilation, was completed and sent for printing.

A paper on the vertical distribution, during the hours of light and darkness respectively, of some of the constituents of the plankton forming the food of herrings and mackerel, based on observations made in past years on the fishery cruiser "Muirchu", was also completed and made ready for the printer.

Owing to war conditions the periodic hydrographic cruises of the fishery cruiser " Muirchu" were suspended throughout 1944, but routine daily recordings of sea temperatures continued to be made at Coningbeg Lightship.

ASSISTANCE TO FISHERMEN.—Throughout 1944 there was no diminution of the difficulties experienced during the previous four years in maintaining vessels in condition as to hull and machinery and procuring the fishing gear and engine oils needed to keep the fleet in commission. Fortunately, this Department and the Irish Sea Fisheries Association succeeded, with the aid of the Department of Supplies, in surmounting these difficulties to a considerable degree. The arrangement whereby the import from Great Britain of a limited quantity of spare parts for marine motor engines was assured remained in operation and reduced somewhat the effects of our fishermen's inability to obtain new motor engines at any price. On the trading side the Association was again able to render valuable service to its members. The total quantity of wet fish marketed by the Association in 1944 was virtually the same as for 1943 (55,000 cwt. against 55,300 cwt.) and the amount disbursed to members was £126,464 in 1944 and £136,936 in 1943. It is interesting to compare these figures with those for 1939, which were 13,800 cwt. and £21,191. The Association's sales of shellfish produced for members £9,835 during 1944 against £5,748 for 1943.